can expand to 300–400 million over the next five, seven years. And imagine what kind of a consumption economy, what kind of an economic powerhouse that would be." So, think of this as being a socialist for a transition period, spending more and more of the government money, making sure you create a larger and larger middle class. When you are forward-thinking like that, suddenly it doesn't sound leftist, rightist, socialist or free-market.'

Did this mean, I asked, a statist approach with some of the guiding instincts of Singapore, but without its low tax rates? No, responded Chandrasekhar. It meant an Indian state with a focus on the local economy and exports. 'Only, if you look at a large enough Indian market, build a large middle class, can you create an export industry of the scale and size of China … Just imagine if 500 million people enter the middle class, what will happen. There would be factories here to make things for 400-500 million Indians: making biscuits, water and so on. That kind of a scale will create an export capability that is unparalleled … What China did in the last ten years, we will have to do in the next ten years. Feeding their burgeoning middle class has caused them [China] to create export capacity for the rest of the world. We can do the same thing. If we create a large enough domestic market alone can we export. We cannot create industries that are for export only. That is why in India today, we have textile factories that export but we have to import almost every synthetic garment from abroad. Finished products we get from Bangladesh and China, cheaper. Textiles we export because the same textile manufacturers are not making products for India.'

Whether India is competitive enough to benefit from the shift of global businesses from China or not, this ambition repeatedly comes up in conversations with senior BJP leaders. The deputy chief minister of UP, Dinesh Sharma, offered the same argument when I met him in June 2020 in Lucknow. The state government's aim, he said, was to ensure that firms leaving China come to UP and 'don't go to Vietnam or elsewhere'.[125]

Was India not losing the opportunity for exports, with businesses leaving China already going to other places that were more competitive, I asked Chandrasekhar. 'I am not saying wake up after six years,' he responded. 'I'm saying that the process that Modi